

A FIRST-TIME GYM OWNER'S PLANNING CHECKLIST

Work through these checks before you commit to a gym space — from the lease and the building to circulation, services and the training programme.

01 BEFORE SIGNING THE LEASE

- [] Confirm permitted use covers a commercial gym, not only 'retail' or 'office'.
- [] Record clear floor-to-soffit height at the lowest beam, duct and sprinkler.
- [] Note column grid, shear walls and any core that will split the floor.
- [] Ask who pays for extra electrical load, water and drainage if the unit cannot take a gym as-is.
- [] Walk the entry, lift and stair with a loaded equipment crate in mind.

02 CHECK THE BUILDING

- [] Measure the real usable rectangle after fire stairs, toilets and landlord plant.
- [] Check slab capacity for heavy racks, plate trees and dense free-weight zones.
- [] Map existing wet areas — toilets, showers, mop sinks — before you draw lockers.
- [] Find the electrical room and confirm spare capacity with the building engineer.
- [] Stand outside at the time of day members will arrive. Noise, light and drop-off all count.

03 THINK ABOUT CIRCULATION

- [] Draw one clear spine from reception to the furthest training zone. Do not cross it with racks.
- [] Keep a path that a stretcher or service trolley can use without moving equipment.
- [] Separate the queue at reception from people walking to the floor.
- [] Give turf, sleds and carry lanes a long, unbroken run — never across the main aisle.
- [] Check sightlines from the trainer desk to the free-weight floor and the studio door.

04 SERVICES

- [] HVAC: a packed floor at 7am needs more air than an empty shell suggests.
- [] Power: racks with screens, cardio banks and a front desk all pull from different circuits.
- [] Water: showers, drinking points and mop sinks should sit on the wet side of the plan.
- [] Drainage falls and grease / hair traps if you are adding a juice bar or treatment room.
- [] Data and CCTV routes so you are not chasing conduits after the floor is down.

05 TEST THE GYM PROGRAMME

- [] List every activity the space must hold at peak: strength, cardio, classes, recovery, retail.
- [] Write the busiest hour. If two programmes clash, the layout will fail first.
- [] Count stations, not just square feet. A 3,000 sq ft floor can still be one programme short.
- [] Decide what can share a zone and what must never share (e.g. Olympic lifting and a cycle class).
- [] Leave a holding area for the next class so the floor does not become a waiting room.

06 FIT-OUT AND EQUIPMENT SEQUENCE

- [] Do not order equipment until the circulation spine and wet rooms are fixed on plan.
- [] Phase year-one equipment vs year-two so the first fit-out is not over-stuffed.
- [] Specify flooring by zone: shock, hygiene, and what members see from the door.
- [] Set a contingency for slab, power and acoustic work the survey will miss.
- [] Walk the drawings with your operator before you freeze the tender set.

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